National
Qualifications
2021 ASSESSMENT RESOURCE

X827/75/11

ESOL
Listening Transcript

Duration — 35 minutes (approx)

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Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 1

The talk below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the talk a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

Where special arrangements have been agreed in advance to allow the reading of the material, it should be read by either one male or one female speaker. Sections marked **(t)** should be read by the teacher.

(t) Recording 1. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 1 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Hello, and welcome to the programme. Few products have shaped the modern world more than plastic. But now people are very worried about the amount of plastic getting into the seas and oceans. So today we'll look at how it gets everywhere and how we can deal with the problem.

Plastic is made from oil and it has many advantages. It's lightweight, it doesn't use much raw material, it doesn't break easily, it resists moisture, humidity and gases. If you think about the food that's sent from farm to fork, one of the long, complex supply chains in modern society, well, packaging protects that food so that at home we can get safe and nutritious food that has long use-by dates.

However, there's more to plastic than packaging. Plastic delivers the water to our houses in our pipes, but before we had plastic pipes these were made from – well, if you go back far enough – from baked clay, which is heavy and can break, or from lead, which will affect people's health, later from steel, which is heavy, so not easy to move around. Also, it's expensive and needs a lot of energy to produce. In fact, plastic has a much lower carbon footprint for its use than a lot of the things it replaced.

If you think about glass bottles, they take an enormous amount of energy to make, and then you use more energy to transport them around, because they're very heavy. People will say that the glass bottle's recyclable, but actually, most of it doesn't get recycled back into another glass bottle. It just gets smashed up. Some of it may get recycled but, we mustn't forget, the energy that's needed to do the recycling is often the problem here. And we could say that it isn't plastic that's going to ruin the planet, it's carbon.

Plastic is cheap to make and it can do many different things. It has enormous strength and it's very lightweight. In aircraft engineering, this light weight means it saves fuel. Packaging material saves millions of tons of food waste, and food waste is a major contributor to climate change, so all of these things are positive.

However, the type of plastic that the public sees most of, and which makes them most angry, is food packaging. Is there a way that we could use less packaging, or use something else?

But sometimes things work against each other. For example, black trays are used for ready meals and they're difficult to recycle. But black trays are actually made from a lot of recycled material, and they're dyed black because that disguises the mixture of plastics that go into them.

Anyway, I welcome the attention that's coming to plastic now because it's forcing the industry to say it has been using too much of it. I mean, I've gone into a supermarket and thought, why have they put that coconut in plastic? Coconuts have shells and they don't need more wrapping.

There are some optimistic signs. A company in Croydon has developed a machine that can change plastic back into oil, the material it was first made from. The **current** problem with recycling plastic is that it has to be sorted, to get rid of the other stuff – black trays, films, crisp packets – which are not mechanically recyclable. But if you turn everything back into oil, then the oil can be changed back into plastic. These machines could be sent to parts of the world where there is a problem with plastic, and put beside rivers, and people could be paid to bring plastic, or get health or education vouchers in exchange.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

[Turn over

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 2

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

Where special arrangements have been agreed in advance to allow the reading of the material, it should be read by one male and one female speaker. Sections marked **(t)** should be read by the teacher.

(t) Recording 2. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 2 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Katia Daniel Clark – it is you, isn't it?

Daniel Er . . . yes . . . Katerina? Katia, yes.

Katia Sure is – haven't seen you since school. What are you doing in Glasgow?

Daniel Take a seat . . . please. I'm just here to see the family. I live in Manchester now.

Katia Manchester? Doing what?

Daniel I work for a company . . . helping companies to improve their online profiles.

Katia You mean like advertising on the Internet?

Daniel No . . . not really. It's called digital marketing. It's more like . . . let's say you've got a website but it never comes near the top of the list when somebody does a search on Google or whatever . . .

Katia Yeah.

Daniel Well, we can help – it's all about putting in more links and stuff. What about you?

Katia Teaching.

Daniel Yes, I remember you said you were interested. So what did . . . which university did you go to?

Katia Aberdeen – did a degree in biology, then teacher training, then I moved back to Glasgow and got a job here.

Daniel And do you enjoy it?

Katia Bits of it – sometimes . . . when things are going well I can get a real buzz out of it. You have good days and bad days, I suppose. But, to be honest, I'm finding it a bit dull at times. Every day, same school, same time. I mean, it's a good enough school, but it isn't very big and I meet the same people in the staff room every day.

Daniel Well, there's only about fifteen in my company. The room where I work, there's just three of us, but we don't talk much because we're staring at computer screens most of the time. I see the others at break times but, well – put it this way, in teaching, I suppose you're all on much the same level – I mean you're all graduates doing the same kind of jobs. But with us, well, some are graduates like me, doing the technical stuff, but there are others doing secretarial things. And then there are some real high-fliers who have forgotten more about the Internet than I've ever learned. We don't all have very much in common.

Katia You should go on a team-building exercise.

Daniel (*laughs*) Actually, we do. We're off to the Welsh mountains for a long weekend soon. We get occasional freebies like that.

Katia Sounds fun. I can't see the school offering something like that.

Daniel The company's very good on the perks side. We've got a coffee maker – decent coffee, all paid for. And there's a kitchen where you can cook your lunch, though most of them just bring sandwiches. There's a fridge with free drinks and sometimes on Fridays after work people stay around and just chill. Oh – and we also get 50% off membership of the local gym.

Katia Wow! We've got a kettle and a biscuit box.

Daniel Well, nobody goes into teaching for the freebies – so there has to be another reason.

Katia Well, the thing is, I never seriously thought of another kind of job. I could have gone into a research laboratory but I didn't want to spend my time looking at bugs down a microscope. I like the human contact of teaching. Also, we get longer holidays than I would in the private sector.

Daniel That's certainly true. It was a bit of a shock when I first joined the company, how many weeks a year I had to work.

Katia But do you enjoy the work?

Daniel Some of it's quite exciting, but it can be boring at times. (*pause*) But that's not the point, really. In a couple of years I want to set up my own business and what I'm doing now is learning the trade.

Katia Hmm – you've kind of got me there. Not much scope for a freelance biologist. In five years' time I'll probably be doing what I'm doing now.

Daniel Well, we've both got our way of getting through the day. (*begin fade*) Can I get you another coffee?

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

Instructions to reader(s):

Recording 3

The conversation below should be read clearly and naturally. After reading the introduction you should pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to read the questions. On completion of the first reading pause for 10 seconds, then read the conversation a second time. On completion of the second reading pause for 1 minute to allow candidates to write their answers.

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(t) Recording 3. Listen to the recording and attempt the questions which follow. You will hear the recording twice. You now have one minute to read the questions in Recording 3 before the recording begins.

(*1 minute pause*)

TONE

Kirsty Welcome to this week's edition of Education Weekly, from me Kirsty Wilson. Today, we'll be looking at how a country with an already successful education system, one which is the envy of the rest of the world, is shaking up the way pupils are taught. Joining me today are two education experts, Janet Morgan and Neil Younger, who have just returned from a fact finding trip to Finland. First, Janet, could you give us a little background?

Janet Thanks Kirsty. Now, if you said to most Scottish pupils, and their parents, 'imagine a country with a 5 hour school day, and 10 weeks' holiday in the summer, where the only national exam is sat by pupils who continue studying until 18.' I think most, er . . . all of them would say, I like the sound of that.

Kirsty I'm sure they would but . . . less time spent in the classroom, longer holidays, fewer exams. This sounds like a recipe for falling standards. Neil . . .?

Neil Well, that's the really interesting thing. For the last 20 years, Finland has enjoyed a reputation for having one of the best education systems in the world. Its 15 year olds regularly score the highest in the global league tables for reading, maths and science. It's up there with countries like Singapore and Japan. If I could add something Janet neglected to mention that Finnish pupils also complete the least amount of homework in the world, averaging less than 2 hours a week compared to just under 10 hours in Singapore.

Kirsty OK, interesting, well, they're obviously doing something right in Finland already, and yet . . . they are changing their education system, Janet?

Janet That's right. You know the saying, 'If it isn't broken, then don't fix it . . .' well, despite already having a system that is amongst the best in the world, Finland is changing the way it teaches its children.

Kirsty OK, so . . . why is that?

Neil Well, in today's digital age where children no longer get most of their knowledge from books and the classroom, it's vital to equip young people with the skills necessary to flourish in the 21st Century. For example, teaching them to think and understand things is more important than giving them lots of facts.

Kirsty I see. Could you give us some specific examples of how they're doing this?

Neil Sure, schools are teaching critical thinking skills, in other words being able to identify fake news. Also how to avoid cyber-bullying . . . and um, also practical IT skills like installing anti-virus software and connecting to a printer.

Kirsty . . . and is it working?

Janet Well, the new approach, Project Based Learning – or PBL for short – has its critics. They say the new lessons are great for the brightest children who, for example, understand what knowledge they need to take away from an experiment. It gives them the freedom to learn at their own pace. But this is not the case for weaker children who need more support and guidance in the classroom. Some teachers feel it's widening the gap between the most and least able students in Finland, a gap that has been historically very small.

Neil Also, if I could just come in here, several teachers complained about increased workload and some older teachers say they are at a disadvantage because they are not as digitally able as younger teachers.

Kirsty So, some teachers aren't entirely convinced of the need to change. Interesting. Finally, because we're running out of time, is there any data to prove that PBL is improving results?

Janet Ah, well, that's the thing. We were told, unsurprisingly, that as they're not too keen on testing in Finland they aren't planning to measure its success for now. They hope that in a couple of years, improved scores by pupils in international tests will prove that Finland is producing young people with the critical thinking, problem solving and IT skills needed to succeed in the 21st century.

Kirsty Well, thank you for coming in today Janet, Neil and I guess the next question is, would such an approach work here in Scotland? But that's for another day. Thanks for listening and goodbye until next week.

(*10 second pause after first reading*)

TONE

(*1 minute pause after second reading*)

TONE

(t) You now have 1 minute to check your answers.

(*1 minute pause*)

This is the end of the listening test.

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